



For Parents, Carers and Guardians

Racism at School: A Guide for Parents

Recognising racism, talking with your child if they are targeted or have used racist language, and working with the school.

Before You Read This guide covers racism and faith-targeted abuse between children.

This guide is about racism and faith-targeted abuse between children, including slurs, "jokes", online content and hate crime. It describes racist language but never repeats it. Some of it may be difficult to read, especially if it connects with your own experience or your child's.

- If you are worried about your child now, contact the school's safeguarding team. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.
- **NSPCC Helpline:** 0808 800 5000, for anyone worried about a child.

About This Guide

This guide helps you recognise when your child is experiencing racism, talk with them about it, respond if your child has used racist language, and work with the school.

- Racism between children is abuse, not banter. Statutory guidance treats it as child-on-child abuse: a safeguarding matter, not only a behaviour matter.
- Any child can be targeted, and any child can repeat racist language they have heard. Both need adults to respond.
- **You don't need to wait for a pattern.** One incident is enough to contact the school.

Key Words

Racism

Treating a child unfairly or with hostility because of their colour, nationality, or ethnic or national origins.

Faith-targeted abuse

Hostility because of religion or belief, including antisemitism and anti-Muslim hatred. It often overlaps with racism.

Prejudice-related incident

What many schools call an incident motivated by prejudice, whether or not it is a crime. Schools record these.

Hate crime

Any crime where the offender shows, or is motivated by, hostility based on race, religion, disability, sexual orientation or transgender identity.

What the Evidence Shows

71%

of hate crimes recorded by the police in England and Wales were race hate crimes

Home Office, 2025

204

antisemitic incidents affecting people and buildings in the UK school sector in 2025

CST, 2026

Home Office figure: year ending March 2025, the latest release, all ages, excluding the Metropolitan Police Service. There are no current official national figures on racism in schools. Checked September 2026.

Statutory guidance for schools says racism and faith-targeted abuse can have a significant impact on a child's welfare, wellbeing and sense of safety, and lists them as child-on-child abuse (Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026, paragraphs 32 and 37).

What It Can Look Like at Different Ages

Age	What you might see
8 to 11	Name-calling, comments about skin, hair, food or lunchboxes, being left out of games. Children may repeat words without knowing what they mean, and may not have words for what happened to them.
11 to 14	Slurs and "jokes" in front of a group, mocking accents or names, racist memes in group chats, "go back to..." comments.
14 to 18	Racist or faith-targeted abuse online and in person, content presenting racism as funny or "the truth", abuse linked to news events, and racist harassment that may be a crime.

Signs to Look For

Your Child May Be Targeted If They

- Don't want to go to school, a club or the bus, or have "stomach aches" on school days
- Seem withdrawn, angry or low after school
- Want to change how they look, speak or dress, or their name
- Say they wish they were a different colour or background
- Laugh off comments as "just banter" while seeming upset

Your Child May Be Involved in Racism If They

- Repeat slurs, stereotypes or "jokes", or content from online videos
- Talk about a group of people as "them" in hostile ways
- Call it "just banter" or say "everyone says it"
- Share racist memes or clips

A pattern can help explain what is happening, but you don't need to wait for it to happen again before contacting the school.

If Your Child Is Targeted

What to Do

- **Stay calm and listen.** Your calm helps them feel safe. Try: "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault."
- **Use open questions.** "Tell me what happened." Avoid "why" questions, which can sound like blame, and don't ask them to repeat the words if they don't want to.
- **Say clearly that racism is wrong**, and that there is nothing wrong with who they are.
- **Don't tell them to ignore it** or toughen up. Help them decide what they want, with the school.
- If your child is in immediate danger or has a serious injury needing emergency help, call 999. Otherwise, contact the school's safeguarding team promptly; use 101 to report a crime that is not an emergency.
- **Don't contact the other child or their family, and don't post about it online.** It can escalate things and affect what the school and police can do.
- Write down what your child said, in their words, and when. Contact the school's safeguarding team, even if it happened outside school.
- **If it's online:** keep messages as they are and don't delete anything. The school can advise on what is needed. Don't share clips or screenshots of the abuse.

If Your Child Has Used Racist Language

Finding out your child has said something racist is hard. It doesn't make them a bad person, but it does need a clear response. Children often repeat what they've seen online or heard from others, or say things to fit in.

First, Check With the School

If another child may be involved or at risk, **contact the school before raising it with your child.** Agree how and when to talk to them, so that the conversation does not increase the risk to anyone, for example by revealing who reported it.

- Then talk calmly. "Tell me what happened." "How do you think it felt for them?"
- Be clear: "Those words are racist. It doesn't matter if it was a joke. It's not OK."
- Be curious about where it came from: friends, games, videos or social media. Look at what they are watching together.

- Work with the school on consequences and on putting things right. A meeting with the other child only happens if that child freely chooses it.
- Notice your own words at home. Children learn from what adults say and laugh at.

Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
"It's just banter"	Jokes about race or religion single a child out for who they are. That's racism, and schools should never pass it off as banter.
"My child should toughen up"	Racism can affect a child's wellbeing and sense of safety. They need support, not to cope alone.
"Children don't understand racism"	Children notice difference early and learn attitudes from what they hear. They can also learn to challenge it.
"I should confront the other parents"	It can escalate things and make your child less safe. Go through the school.
"Talking about race makes it worse"	Talking openly helps children recognise racism and ask for help.

How the School Responds

Schools using **RESPOND** follow a seven-step approach that helps staff respond consistently when they notice or are told about harm.

For children, safeguarding is **relational**: they tell people they trust. For the adults around them, it is also **systemic**: behind every trusted adult is a safeguarding team, with records and procedures that make sure what a child tells one person reaches the people who can help. That is why staff can't promise to keep something just between them and your child.

Step	What staff do
● Recognise	Notice racist language and behaviour, including online, without waiting for a complaint
● Engage	Stop it if it is safe to do so, and listen to the child targeted
● Support	Make sure the child targeted is safe and supported, with dignity
● Pause	Think before acting; no forced apologies or handshakes
● Offer	Model alternatives and explain what happens next
● Notify	Tell the safeguarding team as soon as is practicably possible
● Document	Record what happened, factually, including as a prejudice-related incident

Working with You

- **Parents and carers are partners in keeping children safe.** You know your child best.
- The school will usually involve you when there is a concern about your child.
- Schools can share safeguarding information without asking for consent where it is needed to keep a child safe; data protection law allows this. From 30 September 2026, a new Information Sharing Duty also requires many safeguarding organisations to share relevant information. What is shared must be relevant, necessary and proportionate, go only to those who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. Schools should tell you what they are sharing and why, unless that would put a child at greater risk, and listen to your views and your child's.
- Sometimes the school must speak to other agencies before telling parents, where telling parents first could increase the risk to a child. That decision depends on the circumstances, and it is always about the child's safety.
- The school's safeguarding lead decides whether to involve the police, and how any children responsible are approached. Staff never decide themselves whether a crime has been committed.
- Every child involved gets a response: the child targeted, the child who used the language, and those who watched.
- Any restorative meeting only happens if the child targeted freely chooses it.



Reporting Outside School

- **Emergency:** call 999. Otherwise, you can report a hate crime to the police on 101.

- **True Vision (police online hate crime reporting):** report-it.org.uk.
- **Stop Hate UK:** 0800 138 1625, 24 hours, confidential, independent reporting and support, in the areas where it is funded (check your area at stophateuk.org).
- **Tell MAMA (anti-Muslim hate):** 0800 456 1226 or report online at tellmamauk.org; confidential, and not a replacement for the police.
- **Community Security Trust (CST) (antisemitism):** report online at cst.org.uk/report-incident, or call its 24-hour national number, 0800 032 3263.

You can report to the police as well as to the school. Tell the school if you do, so it can support your child. Contacts checked September 2026.

If Your Child Boards

- Boarders can contact house staff, the DSL or boarding managers at any time, day or night, and an independent person who isn't a member of staff.
- Boarders must not be discriminated against, including because of their cultural or linguistic background. Ask the school how it supports boarders who are far from family.
- Boarders can contact you privately. If your child tells you about racism in the house, contact the school the same day.

Who Can Help

At School

- **The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)** and deputy DSLs: the staff whose job is to keep children safe. Their names are usually on the school website, in the safeguarding policy and on posters around school.
- The school nurse or health centre, and the school counsellor

Outside School

- **NSPCC Helpline:** 0808 800 5000 (Monday to Friday 10am to 4pm), or help@nspcc.org.uk
- **YoungMinds Parents Helpline:** 0808 802 5544 (Monday, Thursday and Friday 9:30am to 4pm; Tuesday and Wednesday 9:30am to 6pm)
- **Childline** (for your child): 0800 1111, free, confidential, any time, or childline.org.uk

- **Emergency:** call 999; police non-emergency: 101

Contacts checked September 2026.

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Parent Guides

Racism at School: A Guide for Parents: Parent Guide 1 - Ages 8 to 18

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Contacts and figures checked September 2026 | Next review: September 2027